

Aphrodite and Eros



The Babylonians have a most disgraceful custom: a native woman once in her life must sit in the sanctuary of Aphrodite and have sex with a stranger. . . . Those possessed of beauty and stature are quickly released, but those who are unattractive remain for quite a while, since they are unable to fulfill the law. Some wait three or four years.

—HERODOTUS, *History of the Persian Wars* 1.199.1–5

AS WE HAVE SEEN, Hesiod describes the birth of Aphrodite after the castration of Uranus and derives her name from the Greek word *aphros* (foam). Hesiod also links the goddess closely with Cythera (see p. 71) and with Cyprus; the latter was especially associated with her worship, particularly in its city of Paphos. Thus, Aphrodite is called both Cytherea and Cypris. Another version of her birth gives her parents as Zeus and Dione. Dione is little more than a name to us, but a curious one, since it is the feminine form of the name Zeus (which in another form is Dios).

Aphrodite Urania and Aphrodite Pandemos

This double tradition of Aphrodite's birth suggests a basic duality in her character or the existence of two separate goddesses of love: Aphrodite Urania or Celestial Aphrodite, sprung from Uranus alone, is ethereal and sublime; Aphrodite Pandemos (Aphrodite of All the People, or Common Aphrodite), sprung from Zeus and Dione, is essentially physical in nature. Plato's *Symposium* elaborates on this distinction and claims that Aphrodite Urania, the older of the two, is stronger, more intelligent, and spiritual, whereas Aphrodite Pandemos, born from both sexes, is more base and devoted primarily to physical satisfaction.¹ It is imperative to understand that the Aphrodite who sprang from Uranus

(despite her sexuality in Hesiod's account) becomes, for philosophy and religion, the celestial goddess of pure and spiritual love and the antithesis of Aphrodite, daughter of Zeus and Dione, the goddess of physical attraction and procreation. This distinction between sacred and profane love is one of the most profound archetypes in the history of civilization.

The Nature and Appearance of Aphrodite

The *Homeric Hymn to Aphrodite* (10), with its brief glimpse of Aphrodite, reminds us of her cult places, Cyprus and Cythera, and the city of Salamis in Cyprus.

I shall sing about Cyprus-born Cytherea, who gives mortals sweet gifts; on her lovely face, smiles are always suffused with the bloom of love.

Hail, goddess, mistress of well-built Salamis and sea-girt Cyprus. Give me a desirable song. Yet I shall remember you and another song too.

In general, Aphrodite is the goddess of beauty, love, and marriage. Her worship was universal in the ancient world, but its facets were varied. At port cities such as Ephesus, Paphos, and Corinth, temple harlots may have been kept in Aphrodite's honor, but the evidence for widespread temple prostitution is lacking. At Athens this same goddess was the staid and respectable deity of marriage and married love. The seductive allurements of this goddess were very great; she herself possessed a magic girdle with irresistible powers of enticement. In the *Iliad* (14. 197–221) Hera borrows it with great effect on her husband, Zeus.

The gamut of the conceptions of the goddess of love is reflected in sculpture as well as literature. Archaic idols, like those of other fertility goddesses, are grotesque in their exaggeration of her sexual attributes. In early Greek art, she is rendered as a beautiful woman, usually clothed. By the fourth century, she is portrayed nude



The Birth of Aphrodite. Ca. 460 B.C.; marble, height (at corner) 33 in. In this three-sided relief (known as the *Ludovisi Throne*), Aphrodite is shown in the center panel rising from the sea and being clothed by two attendants, who stand on a pebbly beach. On the left panel (not shown) a naked musician plays the double flute, and on the right panel (not shown) a veiled woman burns incense. (*Scala/Ministero per i Beni e le Attività culturali/Art Resource, NY*)

(or nearly so), the idealization of womanhood in all her femininity; the sculptor Praxiteles was mainly responsible for establishing the type—sensuous in its soft curves and voluptuousness.² As so often occurred in the ancient world, once a master had captured a universal conception, it was repeated endlessly with or without significant variations. Everyone knows the Venus from Melos or one of the many other extant copies, although Praxiteles' originals have not survived.

Attendants of Aphrodite

The **Graces (Charites)** and the Hours or Seasons (Horae) are often associated with Aphrodite as decorative and appropriate attendants. The Graces, generally three in number, are personifications of aspects of loveliness. The **Horae**, daughters of Zeus and Themis, are sometimes difficult to distinguish from the Graces, but they eventually emerge with clearer identity as the **Seasons**; thus, they usually are thought of as a group of two, three, or four. Horae means “hours” and therefore “time” and thus ultimately “seasons.” The *Homeric Hymn to Aphrodite* (6) focuses on the decking out of the goddess by the Horae, whom in this context we call the Hours.

I shall sing about beautiful and revered Aphrodite of the golden crown, who holds as her domain the battlements of all sea-girt Cyprus. The moist force of the West Wind Zephyrus as he blows brought her there amidst the soft foam on the waves of the resounding sea. The gold-bedecked Hours gladly received her and clothed her in divine garments. On her immortal head they placed a finely wrought crown of gold and in her pierced earlobes, flowers of copper and precious gold. About her soft neck and silvery breasts they adorned her with necklaces of gold, the kind that beautify the Hours themselves whenever they go to the lovely dancing choruses of the gods and to the home of their father. Then after they had bedecked her person with every adornment they led her to the immortals, who greeted her when they saw her and took her in their welcoming hands; and each god prayed that she would be his wedded wife and he would bring her home, as he marveled at the beauty of violet-crowned Cytherea. (1–18)

Hail, sweet and winning goddess with your seductive glance; grant that I may win victory in the contest and make my song fitting. Yet I shall remember you and another song too. (19–21)

The Phallic Priapus

The more elemental and physical aspects of Aphrodite's nature are seen in her son, Priapus.³ His father may be Hermes, Dionysus, Pan, Adonis, or even Zeus. Priapus is a fertility god, generally depicted as deformed and bearing a huge and erect phallus. He is found in gardens and at the doors of houses. He is part scarecrow, part bringer of luck, and part guardian against thieves; therefore, he has something in common with Hermes. He also resembles Dionysus and Pan (two of his other reputed fathers) and is sometimes confused with them or their retinues. Whatever the origins of Priapus in terms of sincere and primitive reverence for the male powers of generation, stories about him usually came to be comic and obscene. In the jaded society of later antiquity, his worship meant little more than a cult of sophisticated pornography.

Aphrodite of Melos (Venus de Milo). Late second century B.C.; marble, height 80 in. This is the best known representation of Aphrodite in the Hellenistic age, after Praxiteles had popularized statues of the unclothed female body with his *Aphrodite of Cnidus* (mid-fourth century B.C.): before Praxiteles, Greek convention had limited nudity in statues, with few exceptions, to the male form. Praxiteles' statue survives only in copies dismissed as "lamentable objects" by Martin Robertson. Unlike them, the *Aphrodite of Melos* is unrestored and half draped. It has aroused passionate criticism, favorable and unfavorable. Its sculptor was probably a Greek from Phrygian Antioch, whose name ended in "... andros." See George Curtis, *Disarmed: The Story of the Venus de Milo* (New York: Knopf, 2003). (*Réunion des Musées Nationaux/Art Resource, NY*)

Pygmalion

Although many stories illustrate the mighty power of Aphrodite, the story of Pygmalion has provided a potent theme (e.g., Shaw's *Pygmalion* and Lerner and Loewe's *My Fair Lady*). Ovid tells how Aphrodite (Venus in his version) was enraged with the women of Cyprus because they dared to deny her divinity; in her wrath, the goddess caused them to be the first women to prostitute themselves, and as they lost all their sense of shame it was easy to turn them into stone. Ovid goes on to relate the story of Pygmalion and the result of his disgust for these women (*Metamorphoses* 10. 243–297).

Pygmalion saw these women leading a life of sin and was repelled by the many vices that nature had implanted in the feminine mind. And so he lived alone without a wife for a long time, doing without a woman to share his bed. Meanwhile he fashioned happily a statue of ivory, white as snow, and gave it a beauty surpassing that of any woman born; and he fell in love with what he had made. It looked like a real maiden who you would believe was alive and willing to move, had not modesty prevented her. To such an extent art concealed art; Pygmalion wondered at the body he had fashioned and the flames of passion burned in his breast. He often ran his hands over his creation to test whether it was real flesh and blood or ivory. And he would not go so far as to admit that it was ivory. He gave it kisses and thought that they were returned; he spoke to it and held it and believed that his fingers sank into the limbs that he touched and was afraid that a bruise might appear as he pressed her close. (243–258)

Sometimes he enticed her with blandishments, at other times he brought her gifts that please a girl: shells and smooth pebbles, little birds, flowers of a thousand colors, lilies, painted balls, and drops of amber, the tears wept by Phaëthon's sisters who had been changed into trees. He also clothed her limbs with garments, put rings on her fingers, draped long necklaces around her neck, dangled jewelry from her ears, hung adornments on her breast. All was becoming, but she looked no less beautiful naked. He placed her on his bed with covers dyed in Tyrian purple and laid her down, to rest her head on soft pillows of feathers as if she could feel them. (259–269)

The most celebrated feast day of Venus in the whole of Cyprus arrived; heifers, their crooked horns adorned with gold, were slaughtered by the blow of the axe on their snowy necks, and incense smoked. When he had made his offering at the altar, Pygmalion stood and timidly prayed: "If you gods are able to grant everything, I desire for my wife. . . ." He did not dare to say "my ivory maiden." Golden Venus herself was present at her festival and understood what his prayers meant. As an omen of her kindly will, a tongue of flame burned bright and flared up in the air. (270–279)



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Audio

When he returned home, Pygmalion grasped the image of his girl and lay beside her on the bed and showered her with kisses. She seemed to be warm. He touched her with his lips again and felt her breasts with his hands. At his touch the ivory grew soft, and its rigidity gave way to the pressure of his fingers; it yielded just as Hymettan wax when melted in the sun is fashioned into many shapes by the working of the hands and made pliable. He is stunned but dubious of his joy and fearful he is wrong. In his love he touches this answer to his prayers. It was a body; the veins throbbed as he felt them with his thumb. Then in truth Pygmalion was full of prayers in which he gave thanks to Venus. At last he presses his lips on lips that are real and the maiden feels the kisses she is given and as she raises her eyes to meet his she sees both her lover and the sky. (280–294) 40

The goddess is present at the marriage that she has made, and now when the crescent moon had become full nine times, Pygmalion's wife gave birth to Paphos, and from him the place got its name. (295–297)

Galatea is the name given to Pygmalion's beloved in later versions of the tale.

Aphrodite and Adonis

In the most famous of her myths, Aphrodite is confused with the great Phoenician goddess Astarte; they have in common as their love a young and handsome youth named by the Greeks Adonis.⁴ Perhaps the best-known version of the story of Aphrodite and Adonis is told by Ovid. Paphos (the son of Pygmalion and Galatea) had a son, Cinyras. **Myrrha**, the daughter of **Cinyras**, fell desperately in love with her own father. Tormented by her sense of shame and guilt, the poor girl was on the point of suicide, but she was rescued just in time by her faithful nurse, who eventually wrenched the secret from her. Although the old woman was horrified by what she learned, she preferred to help satisfy the girl's passion rather than to see her die.

It was arranged that the daughter should go to the bed of her father without his knowing her identity, and their incestuous relations continued for some time until Cinyras in dismay found out with whom he had been sleeping. In terror, Myrrha fled from the wrath of her father. As he pursued her, she prayed for deliverance and was changed into a myrrh tree, which continually drips with her tears. Myrrha had become pregnant by her father, and from the tree was born a beautiful son named Adonis, who grew up to be a most handsome youth and keen hunter. At the sight of him Aphrodite fell desperately in love. She warned Adonis against the dangers of the hunt, telling him to be especially wary of any wild beasts that would not turn and flee but stood firm. Ovid's story continues as follows (*Metamorphoses* 10. 708–739):

These were the warnings of Venus and she rode away through the air in her chariot yoked with swans. But Adonis' courageous nature stood in the way of her admonitions. By chance his dogs followed the clear tracks of a wild boar and frightened it from its hiding place. As it was ready to come out of the woods, the son of Cinyras hit a glancing blow on its side. With its crooked snout the savage beast immediately dislodged the blood-stained spear and made for the frightened youth as he fled for safety. The boar buried its tusk deep within his groin and brought him down on the yellow sand, dying. (708–716)



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As Venus was being borne through the air in her light chariot on the wings of swans (she had not yet reached Cyprus), she heard the groans of the dying boy from afar and turned the course of her white birds toward them. When she saw from the air above his lifeless body lying in his own blood, she rushed down, and rent her bosom and her hair and beat her breast with hands not meant to do such violence. She complained against the Fates, crying: "But still everything will not be subject to your decrees; a memorial of my grief for you, Adonis, will abide forever. The scene of your death will be re-created annually with the ritual of my grief performed. But your blood will be transformed into a flower. O Persephone, you were allowed at one time to change the limbs of the maiden Mentha into the fragrant mint—will I be begrudged then the transformation of my hero, the son of Cinyras?" (717–731) 10

With these words she sprinkled fragrant nectar on his blood which, at the touch of the drops, began to swell just like a gleaming bubble in the rain. In no longer than an hour's time a flower sprang from the blood, red as the thick skin of the fruit of the pomegranate that hides the seeds within. Yet the flower is of brief enjoyment for the winds (which give it its name, anemone) blow upon it; with difficulty it clings to life and falls under the blasts and buffeting. (731–739) 20

Ovid's story predicts the rites associated with the worship of Adonis involving ceremonial wailing and the singing of dirges over the effigy of the dead youth. Obviously, we have here once again a rendition of a recurrent theme: the Great Mother and her lover, who dies as vegetation dies and comes back to life again. Another version of the myth makes this even clearer.



Venus and Adonis, by Paolo Veronese (Paolo Caliari, 1528–1588); oil on canvas, 1584; 83 ½ × 75 in. Adonis sleeps in the lap of Venus, who fans him with a small flag. A cupid restrains one of the hounds, eager for the hunt that will bring the death of Adonis. Veronese transforms the text of Ovid (*Metamorphoses* 10.529–559), with the last moments of the lovers together enriched by the splendid colors of their robes and the darkening sky foreshadowing the tragedy. (Erich Lessing/Art Resource, NY)

Pygmalion and the Image

The painter Edward Burne-Jones completed a sequence of paintings (1875–1878) illustrating the myth of the artist Pygmalion sculpting an image of his ideal woman, who through the agency of Venus comes to life. Burne-Jones was one of a group of artists and poets known as the Pre-Raphaelites. Their avowed purpose encompassed both a rejection of the rigid, academic, aesthetic canons of their own day and a return to the purity and simplicity of Italian art before

The Heart Desires, by Edward Burne-Jones; oil on canvas; 39 × 30 in. The artist Pygmalion stands before a plinth, contemplating the act of creation. He is framed by women in the town, who are seen through the doorway, and a sculpture of the three Graces in traditional pose. The two groups of women suggest a contrast between the real and the ideal, the profane and the sacred. The dichotomy between the two groups of women and the troubled state of Pygmalion's mind is given added intensity by the fractured reflection of the Graces on the floor. (*The Bridgeman Art Library*)



the time of the Italian painter and architect Raphael (1483–1520), hence the term *Pre-Raphaelite*. They eschewed long-accepted compositional rules of art and attempted to combine harmoniously an austere realism with a lush symbolism. Both Burne-Jones (1833–1898) and the designer, artist, and writer William Morris (1834–1896), as exponents of the Pre-Raphaelite movement, drew heavily on stories from Greek myth and Arthurian legends. These poets and artists combined a vivid color or sound palette; a highly charged, though sublimated, eroticism; and a tense, hushed, and somber atmosphere. Burne-Jones and Morris met at



The Hand Refrains, by Edward Burne-Jones; oil on canvas; 39 × 30 in. The artist Pygmalion has created the perfect realization of his ideal woman. He is caught in a moment of hesitation, yearning to touch the object of his desire. Yet the created image is still not alive. That requires the creative energies of a goddess. (The Bridgeman Art Library)

MYTH & CULTURE (Continued)

school and became artistic collaborators. Between 1868 and 1870 Morris published his most famous work *The Earthly Paradise*, a treasury of narrative stories drawn from a variety of sources, including Greek, Norse, and medieval myths and legends. Among the many tales Morris retells is the story of Pygmalion, entitled "Pygmalion and the Image." Burne-Jones made a number of drawings

The Godhead Fires, by Edward Burne-Jones; oil on canvas; 39 × 30 in. Venus, clothed in a diaphanous garment and holding a sprig of myrtle, appears with her doves and roses and by her touch brings Galatea to life, with the words, "Come down, and learn to love and be alive." Venus extends her arm and with her index finger charges the inert figure with life. Is Venus' gesture meant to suggest a comparison with Michelangelo's fresco on the Sistine Chapel ceiling, in which God with a touch of his finger imbues Adam with life? Galatea reaches down to entwine her arms around the arm of Venus. The entwining of their arms reminds the viewer of the embrace of the two women beyond the door in the first painting. Galatea never looks more alive than in this scene. (*The Bridgeman Art Library*)



Closer Look



intended for a lavishly illustrated edition of Morris' *The Earthly Paradise*. The Pygmalion series sprang from those initial drawings. Burne-Jones chose four scenes to delineate the narrative sequence of the tale, with Morris' quatrain lending the titles to each picture in the series.



The Soul Attains, by Edward Burne-Jones; oil on canvas; 39 × 30 in. Pygmalion, in the manner of worshipper, reaches up to touch his beloved. He still wears his reticence like a garment. Can he truly love this woman as a woman? His head faces her torso, but his eye seems turned up from under, as if unable or unwilling to gaze upon her naked body. Galatea looks past him and her hands seem more grasped than grasping. The arrangement of the two figures suggests a comparison with Venus and Galatea in the previous painting. Has Galatea become for Pygmalion the goddess of love? The single rose at her feet is suggestive of this transformation. (*The Bridgeman Art Library*)

When Adonis was an infant, Aphrodite put him in a chest and gave it to Persephone to keep. Persephone looked inside; and once she saw the beauty of the boy, she refused to give him back. Zeus settled the quarrel that ensued by deciding that Adonis would stay with Persephone below one part of the year and with Aphrodite in the upper world for the other part. It is possible to detect similarities between Easter celebrations of the dead and risen Christ in various parts of the world and those in honor of the dead and risen Adonis. Christianity, too, absorbed and transformed the ancient conception of the sorrowing goddess with her lover dying in her arms to that of the sad Virgin holding in her lap her beloved Son.

Cybele and Attis

Parallels to the figures of Aphrodite and Adonis can readily be found in the Phrygian story of Cybele and Attis, yet another variation of the eternal myth of the Great Mother and her lover that eventually spread throughout the Graeco-Roman world.⁵ Cybele was sprung from the earth, originally a bisexual deity but then reduced to a female. From the severed organ, an almond tree arose. **Nana**, the daughter of the god of the river Sangarios, picked a blossom from the tree and put it in her bosom; the blossom disappeared, and Nana found herself pregnant. When a son, Attis, was born, he was exposed and left to die, but a he-goat attended him. Attis grew up to be a handsome youth, and Cybele fell in love with him; however, he loved another, and Cybele in her jealousy drove him mad. In his madness, Attis castrated himself and died.⁶ Cybele repented and obtained Zeus' promise that the body of Attis would never decay.

In her actual worship, Cybele was followed by a retinue of devotees who worked themselves into a frenzy of devotion that could lead to self-mutilation.⁷ The orgiastic nature of her ritual is suggested by the frantic music that accompanied her: the beating of drums, the clashing of cymbals, and the blaring of horns. The myth explains why historically her priests (called **Galli**) were eunuchs. It is also easy to see how the din that attended Cybele could be identified with the ritual connected with another mother-goddess, Rhea, whose attendants long ago hid the cries of the infant Zeus from his father, Cronus, by the clash of their music. So it was that the Curetes became identified with the Galli.

Like Adonis, Attis is another resurrection-god, and their personalities become merged in the tradition. Like Adonis, Attis may die not through his self-inflicted wounds but by the tusk of a boar. Also like Adonis, Attis comes back to life with the rebirth of vegetation.

We have evidence of springtime ceremonies at which the public mourned and rejoiced for the death and rebirth of Attis. We can ascertain, too, the nature of the secret and mystic rites that were also a part of his worship. Frazer provides a compelling reconstruction:

Our information as to the nature of these mysteries and the date of their celebration is unfortunately very scanty, but they seem to have included a sacramental meal and a baptism of blood. In the sacrament the novice became a partaker of the mysteries by eating out of a drum and drinking out of a cymbal, two instruments of music which figured prominently in the thrilling orchestra of Attis. The fast which accompanied the mourning for the dead god may perhaps have been designed to prepare the body of the

communicant for the reception of the blessed sacrament by purging it of all that could defile by contact the sacred elements. In the baptism the devotee, crowned with gold and wreathed with fillets, descended into a pit, the mouth of which was covered with a wooden grating. A bull, adorned with garlands of flowers, its forehead glittering with gold leaf, was then driven on to the grating and there stabbed to death with a consecrated spear. Its hot reeking blood poured in torrents through the apertures, and was received with devout eagerness by the worshipper on every part of his person and garments, till he emerged from the pit, drenched, dripping, and scarlet from head to foot, to receive the homage, nay the adoration of his fellows as one who had been born again to eternal life and had washed away his sins in the blood of the bull. For some time afterwards the fiction of a new birth was kept up by dieting him on milk like a newborn babe. The regeneration of the worshipper took place at the same time as the regeneration of his god, namely, at the vernal equinox.⁸

We are obviously once again in the exotic realm of the mystery religions; this one, like the others, rests on a common fundamental belief in immortality.

The myth of Aphrodite and Adonis, like that of Cybele and Attis, depicts the destruction of the subordinate male in the grip of the eternal and all-powerful Great Goddess, through whom resurrection and new life may be attained.

Aphrodite and Anchises

An important variation on the same theme is illustrated by the story of Aphrodite and Anchises. In this instance, the possibility of the utter debilitation of the male as he fertilizes the female is a key element; Anchises is in dread fear that he will be depleted and exhausted as a man because he has slept with the immortal goddess. As the story is told in the *Homeric Hymn to Aphrodite* (5), we are given ample evidence of the mighty power of the goddess in the universe and a rich and symbolic picture of her devastating beauty. Here Aphrodite is a fertility goddess and mother as well as a divine and enticing woman, epitomizing the lure of sexual and romantic love.

The *Homeric Hymn* begins by telling us that there are only three hearts that the great goddess of love is unable to sway: those of Athena, Artemis, and Hestia. All others, both gods and goddesses, she can bend to her will. So great Zeus caused Aphrodite herself to fall in love with a man because he did not want her to continue her boasts that she in her power had joined the immortal gods and goddesses in love with mortals to beget mortal children but had experienced no such humiliating coupling herself. Although it is this major theme of the union between Aphrodite and Anchises that needs emphasis in this context, the hymn is translated in its entirety, thus preserving its integral beauty and power.

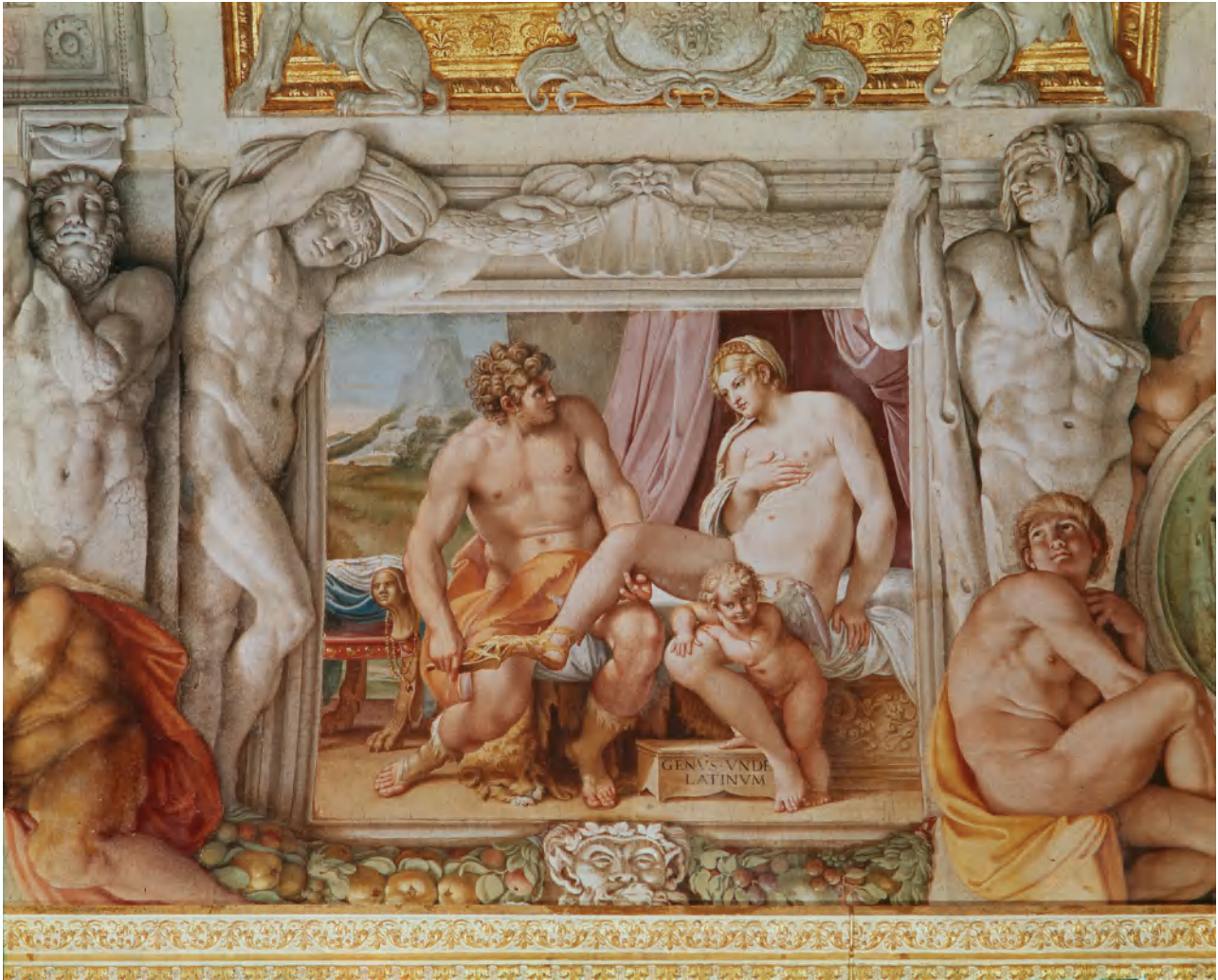
ZEUS' REVENGE ON APHRODITE

Muse, tell me about the deeds of Cyprian Aphrodite, the golden goddess who excites sweet desire in the gods and overcomes the races of mortal humans, the birds of the sky and all animals, as many as are nourished by the land and sea; all these are touched by beautifully crowned Cytherea. (1–6)

Yet she is not able to seduce or ensnare the hearts of three goddesses. First there is the daughter of aegis-bearing Zeus, bright-eyed Athena; for the deeds of



Audio



Venus and Anchises. Fresco from the Galleria of the Farnese Palace, Rome, 1597–1600 by Annibale Carracci (1560–1609): dimensions of the Galleria, 66 × 21 ½ ft. The Farnese Gallery was decorated with Carracci's frescoes of *The Loves of the Gods*, arranged, like Ovid's stories in the *Metamorphoses*, in a complex and logical order. This scene is on the northeast side of the vault, opposite the scene of Zeus making love to Hera. Balancing these two scenes (on the southeast and southwest sides of the vault) are two others of divine lovers, Omphale and Hercules and Diana and Endymion. The Latin inscription on the footstool, on which the smiling Cupid has placed his foot, means "Whence [came] the Roman race," alluding to the birth of Aeneas from the consummation that is about to take place. (*Scala/Art Resource, NY*)

golden Aphrodite give her no pleasure. She enjoys the work of Ares—fights, battles, and wars—and splendid achievements. She first taught craftsmen on the earth to make war-chariots and carriages fancy with bronze. She also teaches beautiful arts to soft-skinned maidens in their homes by instilling the proper skill in each of them. (7–15)

Next, laughter-loving Aphrodite is never able to subdue in love Artemis, the goddess of the noisy hunt, with shafts of gold; for she enjoys her bow and arrows

and killing animals in the mountains, and also the lyre, dancing choruses, thrilling cries, shady groves, and the cities of just mortals. (16–20)

Finally, the deeds of Aphrodite are not pleasing to the modest maiden Hestia, who was the first of the children of crooked-minded Cronus and again the last, by the will of aegis-bearing Zeus.⁹ Poseidon and Apollo wooed this revered virgin, but she did not want them at all and firmly said no. She touched the head of father Zeus, who wields the aegis, and swore that she would be a virgin all her days, this goddess of goddesses—and her oath has been fulfilled. Father Zeus has given her beautiful honor, instead of marriage. In the middle of the home she sits and receives the richest offering, in all the temples of the gods she holds her respected place, and among all mortals she is ordained as the most venerable of deities. (21–32)

The hearts of these three goddesses Aphrodite cannot influence or ensnare, but of everyone else there is no one or nothing among blessed gods or human beings that can escape her. She has led astray even the mind of Zeus, who delights in the thunder, the greatest of all, receiving as his due the highest honor. Whenever she wishes, she easily beguiles even his steadfast heart to mate with mortal women, without the knowledge of Hera, his sister and his wife, who in her great beauty is the best among the immortal goddesses. Wily Cronus and her mother Rhea bore her, most glorious, whom Zeus in his eternal wisdom made his august and prudent wife. Yet, into the heart of Aphrodite herself, Zeus instilled sweet desire to have intercourse with a man so that even she would be guilty of love with a mortal and so that laughter-loving Aphrodite could not ever say, smiling sweetly in mockery among all the deities, that she had mated gods with mortal women, who bore mortal sons to deathless gods and mated goddesses with mortal men. (33–52)

Yet Zeus put into the heart of Aphrodite herself sweet longing for Anchises, who at that time was tending cattle on the high ranges of Mt. Ida with its many streams. In beauty he was like the immortals; and so when laughter-loving Aphrodite saw him, she fell in love, and a terrible longing seized her being. She went to Paphos in Cyprus and entered her fragrant temple. For her precinct and fragrant altar are there. After she went in, she closed the shining doors; inside the Graces (Charites) bathed her and rubbed her with ambrosial oil, the kind used by the eternal gods, and she emerged perfumed in its heavenly sweetness. (53–63)

When she was beautifully clothed in her lovely garments and adorned with gold, laughter-loving Aphrodite left fragrant Cyprus and hastened to Troy, pressing swiftly on her way, high among the clouds. And she came to Ida, the mother of beasts, with its many springs, and crossed the mountain straight for the hut of Anchises. Gray wolves, bright-eyed lions, bears, and swift panthers, ravenous after deer, followed her, fawning. When she saw them, she was delighted within her heart and filled their breasts with desire; and they all went together in pairs to their beds, deep in their shadowy lairs. (64–75)

APHRODITE SEDUCES ANCHISES

She came to the well-built shelter and found him in his hut, left alone by the others, the hero Anchises, who had in full measure the beauty of the gods. All the rest were out following the cattle in the grassy pastures, but he, left alone by the others, paced to and fro playing a thrilling melody on his lyre. The daughter of Zeus, Aphrodite, stood before him, assuming the form of a beautiful young virgin, so that Anchises might not be afraid when he caught sight of her with



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his eyes. After Anchises saw her, he pondered as he marveled at her beautiful form and shining garments. For she wore a robe that was more brilliant than the gleam of fire, and she was adorned with intricate jewelry and radiant flowers, and about her soft throat were exquisite necklaces beautifully ornate and of gold. The raiment about her tender breasts shone like the moon, a wonder to behold. (76–90)

Desire gripped Anchises and he addressed her: “Hail to you, O lady, who have come to this dwelling, whoever of the blessed gods you are, Artemis or Leto or golden Aphrodite or well-born Themis or gleaming-eyed Athena; or perhaps you who have come here are one of the Graces, who are the companions 70 of the gods and are called immortal, or one of the nymphs, who haunt the beautiful woods or inhabit this beautiful mountain, the streams of rivers, and the grassy meadows. I shall build an altar for you on a high mound in a conspicuous spot and I shall offer you beautiful sacrifices in all seasons. Be kindly disposed toward me and grant that I be a preeminent hero among the Trojans; make my offspring flourish in the time to come and allow me myself to live well for a long time and see the light of the sun, happy among my people, and reach the threshold of old age.” (91–106)

Then Aphrodite, the daughter of Zeus, answered him: “Anchises, most renowned of earthborn men, I tell you that I am not any one of the gods. Why do 80 you compare me to the immortals? No, I am a mortal and my mother who bore me was a mortal woman; my father, Otreus, who rules over all Phrygia with its fortresses, has a famous name; perhaps you have heard of him. But I know your language as well as I know our own, for a Trojan nurse reared me in my home in Phrygia; she took me from my mother when I was a very little child and brought me up. And so to be sure I readily understand your language. Now Hermes, the slayer of Argus, with his golden wand, snatched me away from the choral dance in honor of Artemis, the goddess of the golden arrows, who delights in the sounds of the hunt. We were a group of many nymphs and virgins such as 90 suitors pursue, and in a vast throng we circled round about. From here the slayer of Argus with his golden wand snatched me away and whisked me over many places, some cultivated by mortals, others wild and unkempt, through which carnivorous beasts stalk from their shadowy lairs. I thought that I should never set foot again on the life-giving earth. But he told me that I should be called to the bed of Anchises as his lawful wife and that I should bear splendid children to you. And when he had explained and given his directions, then indeed he, the mighty slayer of Argus, went back again among the company of the gods. (107–129)

“But I have come to you and the force of destiny is upon me. I implore you, by Zeus and by your goodly parents (for they could not be base and have such a son as you), take me, pure and untouched by love, as I am, and present me 100 to your father and devoted mother and to your brothers who are born from the same blood. I shall not be an unseemly bride in their eyes but a fitting addition to your family. And send a messenger quickly to Phrygia, home of swift horses, to tell my father and worried mother. They will send you gold enough and woven raiment; accept their many splendid gifts as their dowry for me. Do these things and prepare the lovely marriage celebration which both mortal human beings and immortal gods cherish.” (130–142)

As she spoke thus, the goddess struck Anchises with sweet desire and he cried out to her: “If, as you declare, you are mortal, and a mortal woman is your 110 mother, and Otreus is your renowned father, and you have come here through

the agency of Hermes and are to be called my wife all our days, then no one of the gods or mortals will restrain me from joining with you in love right here and now, not even if the archer god Apollo himself were to shoot his grief-laden shafts from his silver bow. After I have once gone up into your bed, O maiden, fair as a goddess, I should even be willing to go below into the house of Hades.” (143–154)

As he spoke he clasped her hand, and laughter-loving Aphrodite turned away and with her beautiful eyes downcast crept into his bed, with its fine coverings, for it had already been made with soft blankets; on it lay the skins of bears and loud-roaring lions that Anchises had slain in the lofty mountains. And then when they went up to his well-wrought bed, Anchises first removed the gleaming ornaments, the intricate brooches and flowers and necklaces; and he loosened the belt about her waist and took off her shining garments and set them down on a silver-studded chair. Then by the will of the gods and of fate he, a mortal man, lay with an immortal goddess, without knowing the truth. (155–167)

APHRODITE REVEALS HER TRUE IDENTITY

At the time when herdsmen turn their cattle and staunch sheep back to their shelter from the flowery pastures, Aphrodite poured upon Anchises a sleep that was sound and sweet, and she dressed herself in her lovely raiment. When the goddess of goddesses had clothed her body beautifully, she stood by the couch and her head reached up to the well-wrought beam of the roof, and from her cheeks shone the heavenly beauty that belongs to Cytherea of the beautiful crown. She roused Anchises from sleep and called out to him with the words: “Get up, son of Dardanus; why do you sleep so deeply? Tell me if I appear to you to be like the person whom you first perceived with your eyes.” (168–179)

Thus she spoke, and he immediately awoke and did as he was told. When he saw the neck and the beautiful eyes of Aphrodite, he was afraid and looked down turning his eyes away, and he hid his handsome face in his cloak and begged her with winged words: “Now from the first moment that I have looked at you with my eyes, O goddess, I know you are divine; and you did not tell me the truth. But I implore you, by aegis-bearing Zeus, do not allow me to continue to dwell among mortals, still alive but enfeebled; have pity, for no man retains his full strength who sleeps with an immortal goddess.” (180–190)

Then Aphrodite, the daughter of Zeus, replied: “Anchises, most renowned of mortal men, be of good courage and do not be overly frightened in your heart. For you need have no fear that you will suffer evil from me or the other blessed ones; indeed you are beloved by the gods. And you will have a dear son who will rule among the Trojans; and his children will produce children in a continuous family succession. His name will be Aeneas, since I am gripped by a dread anguish¹⁰ because I went into the bed of a man, although among mortals those of your race are always most like the gods in beauty and in stature.” (191–201)

Aphrodite is upset because she can no longer taunt the gods with the boast that she has caused them to love mortals while she alone has never succumbed. She continues to try to justify her actions by glorifying the family of Anchises. She tells the story of Ganymede, who was beautiful and made immortal by Zeus, and relates the sad tale of handsome Tithonus, also of the Trojan royal family, who was beloved by Eos and granted immortality. Aphrodite’s son Aeneas, of

course, emerges eventually as the great hero of the Romans. Here is the conclusion of the *Homeric Hymn to Aphrodite*.



Audio

APHRODITE RECALLS THE BEAUTY OF GANYMEDE AND TITHONUS

“Indeed, Zeus in his wisdom seized and carried off fair-haired Ganymede because of his beauty, so that he might be in the company of the gods and pour wine for them in the house of Zeus, a wonder to behold, esteemed by all the immortals, as he draws the red nectar from a golden bowl. But a lasting sorrow gripped the heart of Tros, for he had no idea where the divine whirlwind had taken his dear son. Indeed, he mourned for him unceasingly each and every day, and Zeus took pity on the father and gave him as recompense for his son brisk-trotting horses, the kind which carry the gods. These he gave him to have as a gift. And at the command of Zeus, Hermes, the guide and slayer of Argus, told everything and how Ganymede would be immortal and never grow old, just like the gods. When Tros heard this message from Zeus, he no longer continued his mourning but rejoiced within his heart and joyfully was borne by the horses that were as swift as a storm. (202–217)

“So also golden-throned Eos carried off Tithonus, one of your race, and like the immortals. Eos went to Zeus, the dark-clouded son of Cronus, to ask that Tithonus be immortal and live forever. Zeus nodded his assent and accomplished her wish. Poor goddess, she did not think to ask that her beloved avoid ruinous old age and retain perpetual youth. Indeed, as long as he kept his desirable youthful bloom, Tithonus took his pleasure with early-born Eos of the golden throne by the stream of Oceanus at the ends of the earth. But when the first gray hairs sprouted from his beautiful head and noble chin, Eos avoided his bed. But she kept him in her house and tended him, giving him food, ambrosia, and lovely garments. When hateful old age oppressed him completely and he could not move or raise his limbs, the following plan seemed best to her. She laid him in a room and closed the shining doors. From within his voice flows faintly and he no longer has the strength that he formerly had in his supple limbs. (218–238)

“I should not choose that you, Anchises, be immortal and live day after day like him; but, if you could live on and on a beautiful man, as you are now, and if you could be called my husband, then grief would not cloud my anxious heart. Now, however, soon you will be enveloped by pitiless old age, which, depleting and destructive, stands beside all human beings and is depised by the gods. (239–246)

“Besides, among the immortal gods there will be disgrace for me, continually and forever, because of you. Before this happened, they used to dread the jeers and schemes with which I used to mate all the immortal gods with mortal women at one time or another; for they were all subject to my will. But now no more will I be able to open my mouth about this power of mine among the gods, since driven quite out of my mind, wretched and blameless, I have been utterly insane—I have gone to bed with a mortal and I carry his child in my womb. (247–255)

APHRODITE FORETELLS THE BIRTH OF AENEAS

“When our baby first sees the light of the sun, deep-bosomed mountain nymphs who inhabit this great and holy mountain will bring him up. They are not the



Amor Vincit Omnia (Love Conquers All) ca. 1601–1602, by Caravaggio (1571–1610); oil on canvas, 75 $\frac{1}{4}$ × 58 $\frac{1}{4}$ in., also known as *Victorious Cupid* and *Earthly Cupid*. Caravaggio painted this work for Vincenzo Giustiniani, a wealthy Genoese who devoted himself to the refined pursuits of an aristocratic gentleman: music, art, and classical studies. Giustiniani kept it concealed behind a curtain to be unveiled as his crowning possession. At first glance this painting offers an immediate, yet profound, interpretation: the capricious and indifferent destruction of higher, human aspirations by the power of Eros. The more deeply we study it, however, the more striking and unsettling it becomes. Depicted is a wanton, prepubescent Cupid with a mischievous, not to say malicious, grin, decked with dark eagle's wings, treading upon a variety of items: instruments of music and art, armor and a martial baton, an astral globe, laurel leaves, a coronet, manuscript paper, and pen. The viewer has caught the boy in an ungainly pose, as if he has just been discovered in a piece of wickedness but doesn't care. The young boy is not an idealized youth, not comely or attractive, as one would expect a respectable Eros to be, but an individual portrait of a real and dubious youth, namely, Franscesco Boneri, nicknamed Cecco da Caravaggio, Cecco being a diminutive of Franscesco; he thus became known as "Caravaggio's Cecco." He appears in other Caravaggio works, most notably *St. John the Baptist*. The unusual posture of Eros in Caravaggio's painting is reminiscent of the sculpture of *Victory* by Michelangelo, his predecessor, who had a profound but ambiguous influence on his work. Michelangelo's male nudes, his Ganymede, and his angelic figures on the Sistine Chapel transform, by their beauty, the erotic into a spiritual symbol or metaphor for human aspirations toward the ultimate, divine love of God. In Platonic terms (see p. 214), profane or sexual love is sublimated into a sacred, intellectual, and sublime passion. Michelangelo's *Victory* idealizes the male form; Caravaggio's Eros portrays a brutally realistic and unashamed portrait of a boy with tarnished wings, raw and animal, who obscenely tramples underfoot the higher ambitions, which for him are nothing more than mere toys to be played with or destroyed at his pleasure. (*Nimatallah/Art Resource, NY*)



Closer Look

same as either mortals or immortals; they live a long time and eat ambrosial food and also with the immortals they join in beautiful choruses of dancers. The Sileni and the keen-eyed slayer of Argus make love to them in the depths of desireful caves. When they are born, pines and high-topped oaks are born along with them on the nourishing earth, beautiful and flourishing trees that stand towering on the high mountains; mortals call their groves sacred and do not cut them down with an axe. Yet when the fate of death stands at their side, these trees first begin to wither in the earth, and then their enveloping bark shrivels and their branches fall off. Together with the trees the souls of their nymphs leave the light of the sun. (256–272) 50

“These nymphs will have my son by their side to bring up. When he has first been touched by the enticing bloom of youth, the goddesses will bring the boy here to show you. Yet so that I may go over with you all that I intend, I shall come back again with my son, about the fifth year. Certainly when you first behold with your eyes this flourishing child, you will rejoice at the sight, for he will be very much like a god; and you will bring him to windy Troy. If any mortal person asks who the mother was who carried him under her girdle, remember to say what I tell you. Say she is the daughter of one of the nymphs, beautiful as a flower, who inhabits this forest-covered mountain. If you speak out and boast like a fool that you were joined in love with lovely-crowned Cytherea, Zeus in his anger will strike you with a smoldering thunderbolt. Everything has been told to you; take it all to heart. Refrain from naming me and be intimidated by the anger of the gods.” Having spoken thus, she soared upward to windy heaven. (273–291) 60

Hail, goddess, guardian of well-built Cyprus; I began with you and now I shall go on to another hymn.

Eros

Eros, the male counterpart of Aphrodite, shares many of her characteristics. He, too, had a dual tradition for his birth. He may be the early cosmic deity in the creation myths of Hesiod and the Orphics or the son of Aphrodite, his father being Ares. At any rate, he is often closely associated with the goddess as her attendant. Eros, like Aphrodite, may represent all facets of love and desire, but often he is the god of male homosexuality, particularly in the Greek classical period. He is depicted as a handsome young man, the embodiment and idealization of masculine beauty.

The *Symposium* of Plato

Plato's *Symposium* provides a most profound analysis of the manifold nature and power of love, especially in terms of a conception of Eros. The dialogue tells of a select gathering at the house of Agathon, a dramatic poet, on the day after the customary celebration with the members of his cast in honor of his victory with his first tragedy. The topic at this most famous of dinner parties is that of love. Each guest in turn is asked to expound on the subject. The speeches of Aristophanes and Socrates, both of whom are present, are by far the most rewarding in their universal implications.¹¹

Aristophanes' Speech in the *Symposium*

Aristophanes' speech (*Symposium* 189c2–193d5) follows the speeches of Pausanias and Eryximachus, two of the other guests.

Men seem to me to have failed completely to comprehend the power of Eros, for if they did comprehend it, they would have built to him the greatest altars and temples and offered the greatest sacrifices, whereas he is given none of these honors, although he should have them most of all. For he is the most friendly to man of all the gods, his helper and physician in those ills, which if cured, would bring about the greatest happiness for the human race. Therefore, I shall try to initiate you into the nature of his power, and you will be the teachers of others. (189c4–189d4)



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THE THREE ORIGINAL SEXES

But first you must understand the nature of mortals and what experiences they have suffered. For our nature long ago was not the same as it is now, but different. In the beginning humankind had three sexes, not two, male and female, as now; but there was in addition, a third, which partook of both the others; now it has vanished and only its name survives. At that time there was a distinct sex, androgynous both in appearance and in name, partaking of the characteristics of both the male and the female, but now it does not exist, except for the name, which is retained as a term of reproach. (189d5–189e5) 10

Furthermore, every human being was in shape a round entity, with back and sides forming a circle; he had four hands, an equal number of feet, one head, with two faces exactly alike but each looking in opposite directions, set upon a circular neck, four ears, two sets of genitals and everything else as one might imagine from this description. He walked upright just as we do now in whichever direction (backward or forward) he wished. When they were anxious to run, they made use of all their limbs (which were then eight in number) by turning cartwheels, just like acrobats, and quickly carried themselves along by this circular movement. (189e5–190a8) 20

The sexes were three in number and of such a kind for these reasons; originally the male was sprung from the sun, the female from the earth, and the third, partaking of both male and female, from the moon, because the moon partakes of both the sun and the earth; and indeed because they were just like their parents, their shape was spherical and their movement circular. Their strength and might were terrifying; they had great ambitions, and they made an attack on the gods. What Homer relates about Ephialtes and Otus and their attempt to climb up to heaven and assail the gods is told also about these beings as well. (190a8–190c1) 30

ZEUS' PUNISHMENT FOR THEIR HUBRIS

Zeus and the other gods took counsel about what they should do, and they were at a loss. They could not bring themselves to kill them (just as they had obliterated the race of the giants with blasts of thunder and lightning), for they would deprive themselves of the honors and sacrifices which they received from mortals, nor could they allow them to continue in their insolence. After painful deliberation, Zeus declared that he had a plan. "I think that I have a way," he said, "whereby mortals may continue to exist but will cease from their insolence by

being made weaker. For I shall cut each of them in two, and they will be at the
 same time both weaker and more useful to us because of their greater numbers,
 and they will walk upright on two legs. If they still seem to be insolent and do
 not wish to be quiet, I shall split them again and they will hop about on one leg.”
 (190c1–190d6) 40

With these words he cut human beings in two, just as one splits fruit which
 is to be preserved or divides an egg with a hair. As he bisected each one, he
 ordered Apollo to turn the face with the half of the neck attached around to
 the side that was cut, so that man, by being able to see the signs of his bisec-
 tion, might be better behaved; and he ordered him to heal the marks of the
 cutting. Apollo turned the face around and drew together the skin like a pouch 50
 with drawstrings on what is now called the belly and tied it in the middle,
 making a single knot, which is called the navel. He smoothed out the many
 other wrinkles and molded the chest using a tool like that of cobblers when
 they smooth out the wrinkles in the leather on their last. But he left a few on
 their bellies around their navels as a reminder of their experience of long ago.
 (190d6–191a5)

And so when their original nature had been split in two, each longed for
 his other half, and when they encountered it they threw their arms about one
 another and embraced in their desire to grow together again, and they died 60
 through hunger and neglect of the other necessities of life because of their
 wish to do nothing separated from each other. Whenever one of a pair died, the
 other that was left searched out and embraced another mate, either the half of
 a whole female (which we now call woman) or of a male. Thus they perished,
 and Zeus in his pity devised another plan: he transferred their genitals to the
 front (for until now they had been on the outside, and they begot and bore their
 offspring not in conjunction with one another but by emission into the earth,
 like grasshoppers). (191a5–191c1)

And so Zeus moved their genitals to the front and thereby had them repro-
 duce by intercourse with one another, the male with the female. He did this for
 two reasons: if a man united with a woman, they would propagate the race and it 70
 would survive, but if a male united with a male, they might find satisfaction and
 freedom to turn to their pursuits and devote themselves to the other concerns
 of life. From such early times, then, love for one another has been implanted in
 the human race, a love that unifies in his attempt to make one out of two and to
 heal and restore the basic nature of humankind. (191c2–191d3)

Each of us therefore is but a broken tally, half a man, since we have been cut
 just like the side of a flatfish and made two instead of one. All who are a sec-
 tion halved from the beings of the common sex (which was at that time called
 androgynous) are lovers of women; many adulterers come from this source,
 including women who love men and are promiscuous. All women who are a 80
 section halved from the female do not pay any attention to men but rather turn
 to women; lesbians come from this source. All who are a section halved from
 the male pursue males; and all the while they are young, since they are slices,
 as it were, of the male, they love men and take delight in lying by their side and
 embracing them; these are the best of boys and youths because they are the
 most manly in nature. Some say that they are without shame, but they do not
 tell the truth. For they behave the way they do not through shamelessness but
 through courage, manliness, and masculinity as they cling to what is similar to
 them. (191d3–192a5)

THE NATURE OF DESIRE

Here is a great proof of what I say. Only men of this sort proceed to politics when 90
they grow up. Once they are men they love boys and do not turn their thoughts
to marriage and procreation naturally but are forced to by law or convention; it is
enough for them to spend their lives together unmarried. In short, then, a man like
this is a lover of men as a boy and a lover of boys as a man, always clinging to what
is akin to his nature. Therefore, whenever anyone of this sort and every other kind
of person encounters the other half that is actually his, then they are struck in an
amazing way with affection, kinship, and love, virtually unwilling to be separated
from each other for even a short time. These are the ones who spend their whole
life together, although they would not be able to tell what they wish to gain from 100
each other. No one would imagine that it is on account of their sexual association
that the one enjoys intensely being with the other; clearly the soul of each desires
something else, which it cannot describe but only hint at obscurely. (192a5–192d2)

Suppose Hephaestus, his tools in hand, were to stand over them as they
lay together and ask: “O mortals, what is it that you wish to gain from one an-
other?” Or when they were at a loss for an answer he were to ask again: “Is this
what you desire, to be together always as much as possible so as never to be
separated from each other night and day? If this is what you desire, I am willing
to fuse and weld you together so that the two of you may become one and the
same person and as long as you live, you may both live united in one being, and 110
when you die, you may die together as one instead of two, united even in the
realms of Hades. Just see if this would be enough to satisfy your longing.” We
know that there is not one person who, after hearing these words, would deny
their truth and say that he wanted something else, but he would believe that he
had heard exactly what he had desired for a long time—namely, to be melted in
unison with his beloved, and the two of them become one. The reason is that
our ancient nature was thus and we were whole. And so love is merely the name
for the desire and pursuit of the whole. (192d2–193a1)

Previously, as I have said, we were one, but now because of our wickedness we
have been split by the god (just as the Arcadians have been split up by the Spar-
tans).¹² There is, too, the fear that if we do not behave properly toward the gods we 120
may again be bisected, just as dice that are divided as tallies, and go around like
the figures cut in profile on steles, split right along their noses. For this reason all
mortals must be urged to pay reverence to the gods so that we may avoid suffer-
ing further bisection and win what Eros has to give as our guide and leader. Let no
one act in opposition to him—whoever does incurs the enmity of the gods. For
if we are reconciled and friendly to the god of love, we shall find and win our very
own beloved, an achievement few today attain. (193a1–193b6)

Eryximachus is not to suppose in ridicule of my speech that I am referring
only to Pausanias and Agathon, since they perhaps happen to be of the class 130
of those who love males by nature. I am referring rather to all men and women
when I say that the happiness of our race lies in the fulfillment of love; each must
find the beloved that is his and be restored to his original nature. If this ancient
state was best, of necessity the nearest to it in our present circumstances must
be best—namely, to find a beloved who is of one and the same mind and nature.
It is right to praise Eros as the god responsible; he helps us most in our pres-
ent life by bringing us to what is kindred to us and offers us the greatest hopes
for the future. If we pay reverence to the gods, he will restore us to our ancient
nature and with his cure make us happy and blessed. (193b6–193d5)

Aristophanes concludes by again imploring Eryximachus not to ridicule his speech; and indeed, in the last analysis, we cannot help but take it very seriously. The invention, the wit, and the absurdity are all typical of the comic playwright, but so is the insight that they so brilliantly elucidate. We do not know how much belongs to the genius of Plato, but it would be difficult to imagine anything more in character for Aristophanes. With or without the outspoken glorification of love between males (inspired perhaps by the company present and certainly preliminary to Plato's own message in Socrates' subsequent speech), we have a vision of the basic need of one human being for another that is astonishingly like our own.

Who can ever forget Hephaestus as he stands before the two lovers and asks what they hope to gain from each other? After all, Aristophanes refers to all men and women when he says that happiness lies in the fulfillment of love and that each must find the appropriate beloved. Who can deny that the complex nature of this most fundamental physical and psychological drive is here laid bare, with a ruthless penetration that is disconcertingly familiar to us, however much the scientific quest for precise definition and vocabulary since the time of Freud has replaced the symbols of mythic art?

The archetypal concept of love as a sensual, romantic, and spiritual striving for a blessed completeness, wholeness, and oneness is basic and universal and it is found everywhere. In American literature, the works of Carson McCullers provide affecting examples, especially *Member of the Wedding*. In music, one could find no better illustration of how pervasive the message is than in John Cameron Mitchell's rock musical, *Hedwig and the Angry Inch*. The text of the moving song "Origin of Love" springs directly from Aristophanes, and the visuals that accompany it in the movie version are most touching in their child-like simplicity.

Socrates' Speech in the *Symposium*

In Socrates' speech, which provides the dramatic and philosophical climax of the dialogue, we move from the conception of love that is elemental and essentially physical to a sublime elucidation of the highest spiritual attainments that Eros can inspire. Another myth is evoked, this time to establish the true nature of the divine being, in opposition to the misconceptions of the previous speakers. Socrates tells how he was instructed in the true nature of Eros by a woman of Mantinea called **Diotima**. Although her historical reality is much debated, it is by no means inconceivable that she was a real person. She makes him realize that Eros is neither good and beautiful nor bad and ugly, but in nature lies somewhere between the two. Therefore, he is not a god. Socrates continues his argument quoting from his conversation with Diotima (*Symposium* 201d1–212c3):

DIOTIMA INSTRUCTS SOCRATES ABOUT THE TRUE NATURE OF EROS

"What then might love be," I said, "a mortal?" "Not in the least," she replied. "But what is he then?" "As I told you earlier, he is not mortal or immortal but something between." "What then, O Diotima?" "A great spirit, O Socrates; for every spirit is intermediate between god and human beings." "What power does he have?" I asked. "He interprets and conveys exchanges between gods and



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human beings, prayers and sacrifices from human beings to gods, and orders and gifts in return from gods to human beings; being intermediate he fills in for both and serves as the bond uniting the two worlds into a whole entity. Through him proceeds the whole art of divination and the skill of priests in sacrifice, ritual, spells, and every kind of sorcery and magic. God does not have dealings with mortals directly, but through Love all association and discourse between the two are carried on, both in the waking hours and in time of sleep. The one who is wise in such matters as these is a spiritual being, and he who is wise in other arts and crafts is his inferior. These spirits are many and of every kind and one of them is Eros." (202d8–203a8) 10

"Who were his father and mother?" I asked. "Although it is a rather long story, I shall tell you," she replied. "When Aphrodite was born, the gods held a feast and among them was **Resourcefulness** (*Poros*), the son of **Cleverness** (*Metis*), and while they were dining, **Poverty** (*Penia*) came and stood about the door to beg, since there was a party.¹³ Resourcefulness became intoxicated with nectar (for wine did not yet exist) and went into the garden of Zeus where, overcome by his condition, he fell asleep. Then Poverty, because of her own want and lack of resourcefulness, contrived to have a child by Resourcefulness, and she lay by his side and conceived Eros. And so Eros became the attendant and servant of Aphrodite, for he was begotten on her birthday and he is by nature a lover of beauty and Aphrodite is beautiful. (203a9–203c4) 20

"Since Eros then is the son of Resourcefulness and Poverty, he is fated to have the following kind of character. First of all, he is continually poor, and far from being soft and beautiful as many believe, he is hard and squalid, without shoes, without a home, and without a bed; he always sleeps on the ground, in doorways, and on the street. Thus he has his mother's nature, with want as his constant companion. On the other hand, like his father, he lays his plots to catch the beautiful and the good; being vehement and energetic, he is a dread hunter, always weaving some scheme; full of resource, he has a passion for knowledge and is a lover of wisdom during all his life, a clever wizard, sorcerer, and sophist. He is not immortal nor is he mortal, but at one time he flourishes and lives whenever he is successful, and at another he dies all in the same day, but he will come back to life again because of his nature inherited from his father—what he acquires slips away from him again, and so Eros is never either poor or rich and he is in a state between wisdom and ignorance. This is the way he is. No one of the gods loves wisdom and longs to become wise, because he is wise; and so with any other who is wise—he does not love wisdom. On the other hand, the ignorant do not love wisdom or long to become wise. Ignorance is a difficult thing for this very reason, that the one who is neither beautiful nor good nor wise is completely satisfied with himself. The one who does not think he is lacking in anything certainly does not desire what he does not think he lacks." (203c5–204a7) 30 40

"O Diotima," I asked, "who are those who love wisdom if not the wise or the ignorant?" "By now certainly it would be clear even to a child," she replied, "that they are those who are in a state between desire and wisdom, one of whom is Eros. To be sure, wisdom is among the most beautiful of things and Eros is love of beauty; and so Eros must be a lover of wisdom, and being a lover of wisdom he lies between wisdom and ignorance. The nature of his birth is the reason for this. He springs from a wise and resourceful father and a mother who is not wise and without resources. This then, my dear Socrates, is the nature of this 50

spirit. The conception you had of Eros is not surprising. You believed, to infer from what you said, that Love was the beloved (the one who is loved) and not the lover (the one who loves). For this reason, I think, Love appeared to you to be all beautiful. For that which is loved is that which actually is beautiful and delicate, perfect and most happy, but that which loves has another character, of the kind that I have described.” (204a8–204c6) 60

Diotima goes on to explain the function, purpose, and power of Eros in human life. Love and the lover desire what they do not possess, namely, the beautiful and the good, and the ultimate goal of their pursuit is happiness. Love finds particular expression in the procreation of what is beautiful, both physically and spiritually; and all human beings in their quest to bring forth beauty and knowledge are thereby touched by a divine harmony with the immortal. Procreation is the closest means by which the human race can attain to perpetuity and immortality; love, then, is a love of immortality as well as of the beautiful and the good.

Animals, as well as human beings, seek to perpetuate themselves and thereby become immortal. But for humans there are various stages in the hierarchy of love. The lowest is that of the animal inspired by the desire for children of the body, but as one ascends, there is the realization of the possibility of producing children of the mind. Who would not prefer the poetic offspring of a Homer or a Hesiod and the more lasting glory and immortality that they have achieved? Just as on the rungs of a ladder we proceed from one step to another, so initiates into the mysteries of love move from the lower to the higher.

Love begins with the physical and sensual desire for the beautiful person or the beautiful thing. From the specific object one moves to the generic conception of beauty, which is wondrous and pure and universal. It is the love of this eternal beauty (and with it the goodness and wisdom it entails) that inspires the pursuit of philosophy in the philosopher.

Diotima describes comprehension of the true nature of love in terms of a philosophical and spiritual journey, not unlike the progressive stages of initiation into religious mysteries, culminating in ultimate revelation and knowledge.

THE PLATONIC EROS

“It is necessary for the one proceeding in the right way toward his goal to begin, when he is young, with physical beauty; and first of all, if his guide directs him properly, to love one person, and in his company to beget beautiful ideas and then to observe that the beauty in one person is related to the beauty in another. If he must pursue physical beauty, he would be very foolish not to realize that the beauty in all persons is one and the same. When he has come to this conclusion, he will become the lover of all beautiful bodies and will relax the intensity of his love for one and think the less of it as something of little account. Next he will realize that beauty in the soul is more precious than that in the body, so that if he meets with a person who is beautiful in his soul, even if he has little of the physical bloom of beauty, this will be enough and he will love and cherish him and beget beautiful ideas that make the young better, so that he will in turn be forced to see the beauty in morals and laws and that the beauty in them all is related.” (210a4–210c5) 10

Socrates and Eros

Plato's message in the *Symposium* is in accord with his beliefs generally: sexual activity belongs at the lowest level in the ascent to a spiritual, nonsexual, philosophical Eros. In his *Republic*, the highest order of society, the philosopher kings (which include women), engage in sexual activity only at certain times solely for the purpose of procreation. This is impersonal and pragmatic sex. Platonic, true love (which sexual intercourse can endanger and contaminate) inspires their mutual pursuit of knowledge and service to the state. In the *Dialogues* there is ample evidence that Socrates was overwhelmed by the beauty of young men; he is stimulated and inspired, but he presumably never succumbs sexually. At the culmination of the *Symposium* with the dramatic resolution of its mighty themes, Alcibiades (who has never really understood Socrates' philosophical message) tells of his futile attempts to seduce Socrates. His failure is inevitable. Socrates is Plato's exemplar of the way it should be, the philosopher conquering and sublimating lower instincts in the service of his (or her) higher intellect. In his last work, *Laws*, Plato actually condemns homosexual acts. This should not be surprising or judged to be a contradiction of his earlier views. On the contrary, his condemnation represents a logical and final development of his convictions about sex.¹⁴

This then is the Platonic Eros, a love that inspires the philosopher to self-denial in the cause of humanity and in the pursuit of true wisdom. Presumably, this philosophic Eros can ultimately be aroused from any type of love, heterosexual as well as homosexual (both male and female); the crucial issue is that it be properly directed and become transformed from the erotic to the intellectual. According to Plato in his *Republic*, certain men as well as certain women can attain the highest goals of the true philosopher king. As we have just learned, this cannot be achieved without the sensual and sublime impetus of Eros. Whatever the physical roots, the spiritual import is universal, kindred to the passionate love of God that pervades all serious religious devotion. Aristotle too thinks in Platonic terms when he describes his god as the unmoved mover, the final cause in the universe, who moves as a beloved moves the lover.

How far we have come from the traditional depiction of Eros as the handsome young athlete who attends Aphrodite! Even more remote is the image that later evolved of Eros as Cupid, a chubby mischievous little darling with wings and a bow and arrow. He still attends Aphrodite; and although the wounds he inflicts can inspire a passion that is serious and even deadly, too often he becomes little more than the cute and frivolous *deus ex machina* of romantic love.

Cupid and Psyche

Finally, the story of Cupid and Psyche remains to be told. It is given its classic form by Apuleius, a Roman author of the second century A.D., in his novel *Metamorphoses*, or *The Golden Ass* (4. 28–6. 24). One's first impressions about a

Cupid and Psyche, by Jacques-Louis David (1748–1825); oil on canvas, 1817; 72 ½ × 95 in. Painted by David in Brussels (where he was exiled for the last nine years of his life), this work has always been controversial and, at the least, disturbing. The focus is on Cupid, while Psyche sleeps on the couch where they have made love, **her symbol, a butterfly, hovering above.** Cupid's expression is that of a satiated conqueror, an amoral exploiter of the young woman for whom trials and labors lie ahead before she can achieve eternal union with her lover. The landscape, seen through the window in the background, alone gives hope for Psyche's liberation from her oppressive lover. This psychological interpretation of myth was achieved nearly a century before Freud: it confounded David's contemporaries and still discomforts its viewers. (Jacques-Louis David [French, 1748–1825]. *Cupid and Psyche*, 1817. Oil on canvas, 184.2 x 241.6 cm. The Cleveland Museum of Art, Leonard C. Hanna, Jr. Fund 1962.370)



tale uniting Cupid (or Eros) with Psyche (Soul) should inevitably be Platonic; but whatever philosophical profundities, Platonic or otherwise, have been detected in Apuleius' allegory, popular and universal motifs common to mythology in general and folktale, fairytale, and romance in particular emerge with striking clarity: for example, the mysterious bridegroom, the taboo of identification, the hostile mother figure, the jealous sisters, the heroine's forgetfulness, the imposition of impossible labors accomplished with divine assistance—among them descent into the very realm of Hades—and the triumph of romantic love. In this tale, which begins "Once upon a time" and ends "happily ever after," Cupid appears as a handsome young god with wings. Here is a summary of Apuleius' version.¹⁵

Once upon a time, a certain king and queen had three daughters, of whom Psyche, the youngest, was by far the most fair. In fact, many believed that she was Venus reincarnated and paid her such adulation that the goddess became outraged. And so Venus ordered her son Cupid to make Psyche fall in love with the most base and vile of mankind; instead, Cupid himself fell in love with Psyche. Psyche's inferior sisters had easily found husbands, but Psyche remained unmarried since she was admired by all with the awe that is inspired by divinity. Her father suspected that a god's wrath was responsible. He consulted Apollo, who demanded that Psyche be decked out like a corpse and placed on a mountaintop to be wed by a terrifying serpent.

Therefore, Psyche, amid the rites of a funeral for a living bride, was left on a mountaintop to meet a fate that she finally accepted with resignation. Psyche fell into a deep sleep, and the gentle breezes of Zephyrus wafted her down to a

beautiful valley. When she awoke, she entered a magnificent palace, where her every wish was taken care of. And when Psyche went to bed, an anonymous bridegroom visited her, only to depart quickly before sunrise. Thus Psyche spent her days—and her nights—in the palace.

Meanwhile, her sisters set out in search of her; but her mysterious husband continually warned her not to respond to them when they approached. Alone in her prison all day, Psyche besought her husband each night to allow her to see her sisters and give them gold and jewels. He finally consented on the condition that she must not, despite her sisters' urgings, try to learn his identity. When the sisters arrived and interrogated her, Psyche kept her secret—although she did say that her husband was a very handsome young man.

The sisters returned home with the riches that Psyche had given them, but in their hearts they nursed an all-consuming jealousy. The mysterious bridegroom warned Psyche of her sisters' treachery: their purpose was to persuade her to look upon his face; if she did so, she would never see him again. He also told her that she was pregnant, and if she kept their secret, their child would be divine; if she did not, it would be mortal. Nevertheless, he granted Psyche's appeal to see her sisters once again. In answer to their questions, Psyche revealed that she was pregnant. The sisters once again returned home laden with gifts, but more jealous than ever; they now suspected that Psyche's lover must be a god and her expected child divine.

The evil sisters visited Psyche a third time; this time they told her that her husband really was the monstrous serpent of the oracle and that she would be devoured when the time of her pregnancy was completed. Psyche was horrified and, believing that she was sleeping with the monster, forgot the warnings of her husband and took her sisters' advice. She was to hide a sharp knife and a burning lamp; when the monster was asleep, she was to slash it in the neck.

In anguish, Psyche made her preparations; in the night her husband made love to her and then fell asleep. As she raised the lamp, knife in hand, she saw the sweet, gentle, and beautiful Cupid. Overcome by the sight, her first impulse was to take her own life, but this she was unable to do. Spellbound by Cupid's beauty, she gazed at his lovely wings and fondled the bow and quiver that lay at the foot of their bed; she pricked her thumb on one of the arrows and drew blood. Overcome by desire, she kissed her husband passionately. Alas, the lamp dropped oil on the god's right shoulder. Cupid leaped out of bed and attempted to fly away at once; Psyche caught hold of his right leg and soared aloft with him, but her strength gave way and she fell to earth. Before flying away, Cupid admonished her from a nearby cypress: he had ignored Venus' command, he said, and had taken her as his love; he had warned her; his flight was penalty enough; and her sisters would pay for what they had done.

Psyche attempted to commit suicide by throwing herself in a nearby river; but the gentle stream brought her safely to its bank. She was advised by Pan to forget her grief and win back Cupid's love. In her wanderings, she came to the very city where one of her sisters lived. Psyche told her sister what had happened but added that Cupid would marry the sister if she hastened to his side. The sister called on Zephyrus to carry her from a mountaintop to Cupid's palace, but as she leaped into the air she fell and perished on the rocks below. Psyche then found her way to her other sister, who died in the same manner.

Psyche wandered in search of Cupid. He lay in his mother's bedroom, moaning because of his burn; Venus, learning of what had happened, rushed to her

son's side, berated him for his behavior, and vowed revenge. In a rage, Venus left to pursue Psyche but eventually abandoned her search. She approached Jupiter, who agreed to send Mercury to make a public proclamation for the capture of Psyche. When she was brought before Venus, the goddess denounced and abused her. In addition, Venus imposed upon the poor girl a series of impossible tasks.

First, Psyche was ordered to sort out before nightfall a vast heap of mixed grains (wheat, barley, and the like). In this endeavor, an ant came to her rescue and summoned his army to isolate each different grain.

The next day Venus ordered Psyche to go to a riverbank where dangerous sheep with thick golden fleeces grazed and to bring back some of their wool. This time, a reed murmured instructions. She was to wait until the sheep had stopped their frenzied wandering under the blazing sun; and when they had lain down to rest, she was to shake from the trees under which they passed the woolly gold clinging richly to the branches. And so she accomplished the task. Still not satisfied, Venus ordered Psyche to go to the top of a high mountain, from which dark water flowed—water that ultimately fed the Underworld stream of Cocytus. Psyche was to bring back a jar filled with this chill water; among the terrors to be faced was a dragon. The eagle of Jupiter swooped down and filled the jar for Psyche.

Angrier now than ever, Venus imposed the ultimate task—descent into the realm of Hades. Psyche was ordered to take a box to Persephone and ask her to send back in it a fragment of her own beauty. In despair, Psyche decided to throw herself off a high tower. But the tower spoke to her and gave her specific directions to the Underworld and instructions about what she was and was not to do. Among the stipulations was that she provide herself with sops to mollify Cerberus and money to pay the ferryman Charon. Most important, the tower warned Psyche not to look into the box. Psyche did everything that she had been told, but she could not resist looking into the box. Inside the box was not beauty but the sleep of the dark night of the Underworld; by this deathlike sleep Psyche was enveloped.

By now cured of his burn, Cupid flew to Psyche's rescue. He put sleep back into the box and reminded Psyche that her curiosity once again had gotten the better of her. She was to go and complete her task. Cupid then appealed to Jupiter, who agreed to ratify his marriage with Psyche; since Psyche was made one of the immortals, Venus was appeased. Here is how Apuleius describes the glorious wedding feast on Olympus that marked the happy ending of the story of Cupid and Psyche (*Metamorphoses* 6. 23–24):

Immediately a wedding feast appeared. The bridegroom took the highest place, embracing Psyche. So Jupiter with his own Juno took his place and then, in order, the other gods. Then Jupiter's cupbearer, the shepherd boy Ganymede, brought him a cup of nectar, the wine of the gods, and Bacchus gave nectar to the others. Vulcan cooked the feast; the Hours decorated everything with roses and other flowers. The Graces sprinkled the scent of balsam, and the Muses played and sang. Apollo sang to the cithara and Venus danced in all her beauty to the music; the tableau was so fitting for her that the Muses accompanied her with choral odes or played upon the tibia; a satyr and Pan played the pipes.

So, with all due ceremony, Psyche was married to Cupid and, in due time, a daughter was born to them, whom we call Pleasure (*Voluptas*).

Sappho's Aphrodite

It is impossible to survey the mythological concepts of love without including the poetic vision of Sappho, the lyric poetess¹⁶ of love from the island of Lesbos. Only a little of her work has survived, but the critical acclaim for her artistry glows undiminished. We know practically nothing with certainty about her life and career. She was devoted to Aphrodite and to the young women with whom she was associated. But we cannot even confidently speak about a cult of the goddess, and her relations with her loved ones can legitimately be imagined only from the meager remains of her poetry. Her circle has been interpreted as everything from a finishing school for girls in the Victorian manner to a hotbed of sensuality. From Sappho comes the term *lesbian* and the association of Aphrodite with lesbian love.

In a fervent and moving poem, she calls on Aphrodite for help to win the love of a young woman with whom she has been involved. The literal details of their relationship may be open to endless, subjective interpretation, but Sappho's passionate desperation seems overwhelmingly apparent. Her invocation to Aphrodite has real meaning for us in this context because it illustrates beautifully the intensity that infuses so much of Greek art within the disciplined control of artistic form. It reminds us, too, of the sincerity of the conception of the goddess that was possible in the seventh and sixth centuries B.C. Too often our sensibilities are numbed by the later artificial and conventional stereotypes to which the gods are reduced, once all genuine belief is gone. There can be no question about the reality of Aphrodite in the following lines.

Exquisitely enthroned, immortal Aphrodite,
weaver of charms, child of Zeus,
I beg you, reverend lady,
do not crush my heart
with sickness and distress.
But come to me here,
if ever once before you heard
my cry from afar and listened
and, leaving your father's house,
yoked your chariot of gold. (1.7–8)

10

Beautiful birds drew you swiftly
from heaven over the black earth
through the air between
with the rapid flutter of their downy wings.
Swiftly they came and you,
O blessed goddess,
smiling in your immortal beauty asked
what I wished to happen most
in my frenzied heart. (9–18)

"Who is it this time you desire
Persuasion entice to your love?
Who, O Sappho, has wronged you?"

20



Audio

For if she runs away now,
 soon she will follow;
 if she rejects your gifts,
 she will bring gifts herself;
 if she does not now,
 soon she will love,
 even though she does not wish it." (18–24)

Come to me now too,
 free me from my harsh anxieties;
 accomplish all that my heart longs for.
 You, your very self,
 stand with me in my conflict. (25–28)

30

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Homeric Hymn 5	<i>To Aphrodite</i>
Homeric Hymn 6	<i>To Aphrodite</i>
Homeric Hymn 10	<i>To Aphrodite</i>
Ovid	<i>Metamorphoses</i> 10.243–297; 10.708–739
Plato	<i>Symposium</i> 189c2–193d5; 201d1–212c3
Sappho	Poem 1

Additional Sources

Pausanias	<i>Description of Greece</i> 7.17.9–12
Theocritus	<i>Idyll</i> 15
Xenophon	<i>Symposium</i> 8.9–15

Notes

1. In the speech of Pausanias.
2. His mistress, the courtesan Phryne, was said to be his model, and some claim that Aphrodite herself asked: “Where did Praxiteles see me naked?”
3. Aphrodite’s union with Hermes produced Hermaphroditus, whose story is told at the end of Chapter 12.
4. Many of Aphrodite’s characteristics are Oriental in tone, and specific links can be found that are clearly Phrygian, Syrian, and Semitic in origin.
5. Cf. the Assyro-Babylonian myth of Ishtar and Tammuz.
6. Catullus (63) makes the anguish, love, and remorse of Attis the stuff of great poetry. For a translation, see www.classicalmythology.org.
7. Her worship was introduced into Rome in 205. Lucretius (*De rerum natura* 2. 600–651) presents a hostile but vivid account of its orgiastic nature. For Lucretius, the very nature of deity is that it exists forever tranquil and aloof, untouched by the human condition and immune to human prayers. See also p. 685.
8. James G. Frazer, *The Golden Bough: A Study in Magic and Religion*. Abridged edition (New York: Macmillan, 1922), p. 408. One might want to read Theocritus, *Idyll* 15, for a picture of the worship of Adonis in a Hellenistic city.
9. Hestia, the first-born of Cronus, was the first to be swallowed and the last to be brought up.
10. The name Aeneas is here derived from the Greek *ainos*, which means “dread.”
11. There has been much discussion about the *Symposium* as a reflection of Athenian views generally about homosexuality. One wonders how typical of the mores of Victorian England would have been the speeches (however profound) of a select group of friends at a dinner party given by Oscar Wilde, who actually does have several things in common with the personality and style of the dramatist Agathon, the host of the *Symposium*. (For more about homosexuality, see pp. 22–23).
12. This reference to the dispersion of the inhabitants of Mantinea (an Arcadian city) by the Spartans in 385 B.C. is an anachronism since the dramatic date of the speech is purportedly 416 B.C.
13. It is difficult to find one word that expresses adequately the abstract conceptions personified. The name Poros also suggests contrivance; Metis, wisdom or invention; and Penia, need.

14. For more on this subject, see the perceptive discussion by Byrne Fone, *Homophobia: A History* (New York: Metropolitan Books [Henry Holt], 2000), Chapter 1, “Inventing Eros.” An aspect of the art of Plato in his complex portrait of Socrates is illuminated by Catherine Osborne, *Eros Unveiled* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1994); in her chapter “Eros the Socratic Spirit,” she concludes (p. 100): “The resemblance between Diotima’s picture of Eros and Plato’s picture of Socrates is remarkable.”
15. *Cupid and Psyche* may be compared thematically to *Beauty and the Beast*. See Graham Anderson, *Fairytale in the Ancient World* (London: Routledge, 2000), pp. 61–77.
16. We deliberately use the designation “poetess” rather than “poet” because we concur with the sensible observation of Joan Breton Connelly that “gender differentiation has real meaning in ancient society.”

For additional resources related to this chapter, go to www.oup.com/us/morford.

Artemis

Some children—people don't recall the exact number—playing around the sanctuary found some rope, and having tied it round the neck of the statue pretended that Artemis was being hanged. The Caphyans, when they discovered what the children had done, stoned them to death. A sickness then fell upon the wives of those who had done these things and they gave premature birth to stillborn babies. For this reason the Pythia decreed that they bury the children who had been stoned and offer sacrifice to them every year, since they had been unjustly killed. To this day the Caphyans perform this ritual in accordance with the oracle and call Artemis . . . the Hanged Goddess.

—PAUSANIAS, *Description of Greece* 8.23.6–7



THE HOMERIC HYMN TO ARTEMIS (27) draws the essential features of her character and appearance: beautiful virgin of the hunt, armed with bow and arrows.

I sing about Artemis of the golden arrows, chaste virgin of the noisy hunt, who delights in her shafts and strikes down the stag, the very own sister of Apollo of the golden sword. She ranges over shady hills and windy heights, rejoicing in the chase as she draws her bow, made all of silver, and shoots her shafts of woe. The peaks of the lofty mountains tremble, the dark woods echo terribly to the shrieks of wild beasts, and both the earth and fish-filled sea are shaken. But she with dauntless heart looks everywhere to wreak destruction on the brood of animals. But when the huntress, who delights in her arrows, has had her fill of pleasure and cheered her heart, she unstrings her curved bow and makes her way to the great house of her dear brother, Phoebus Apollo, in the rich land of Delphi, where she supervises the lovely dances of the Muses and the Graces. After she has hung up her unstrung bow and arrows, she takes first place and, exquisitely attired, leads the dance. And they join in a heavenly choir to sing how

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